

A Crocodile Missing Its Snout Tip Gets a Name Inspired by the Great Sphinx

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The Great Sphinx in Giza, Egypt, is famous for its missing nose. Now scientists have named a new **species** of **extinct** crocodile whose **fossil** skull is also missing the tip of its **snout**.

The **species** is called *Herugavialis cairensis*. It is described in a new study in the journal Royal Society Open Science.

The crocodile was a gavial. Gavials are crocodiles with long, thin **snouts**. Only two **species** are alive today, and they live in fresh water in India and nearby countries and in Southeast Asia. But **fossils** show gavials once lived all over the world, often in shallow seas.

In the 1920s, several crocodile **fossils**, including a nearly complete skull, were dug up from Egypt's 45-million-year-old Mokattam **Formation**, a layer of rock. Popular Science describes the find as coming from the rocks of the Great Sphinx. At first, scientists thought the skull belonged to a type of crocodile still alive today, called the false gharial, because the two look alike.

Over the past 100 years, new tools have made it easier to look inside **fossil** skulls. When researchers studied this one again, they found it was a different, new **species**.

The missing **snout** tip gave them an idea for the name. "Given this coincidence with the famously missing nose of the Great Sphinx, we decided to name the new crocodile after the Egyptian god Heru," said study co-author Philip Mannion of University College London.

Long ago, the region was covered by shallow seas that held at least two other kinds of gavials. Co-author Paul Burke of the Swedish Museum of Natural History said the number of crocodile kinds around the Mediterranean rose and fell with changes in temperature and sea level. All crocodiles there disappeared when the Mediterranean dried up about 6 million years ago.

Word Treasure

extinct -- No longer living anywhere on Earth.

species -- A group of living things that are alike and can have young together.

fossil -- The preserved remains or traces of a living thing from long ago, often found in rock.

snout -- The long front part of an animal's face, including its nose and mouth.

formation -- A distinct layer or body of rock that formed during a certain period of time.

Background you need

Fossils form when the remains of living things are buried and slowly preserved in rock over very long periods of time.

Scientists name each new species with a two-part scientific name, and they sometimes choose names that honor places, people or legends.

Gavials are a group of crocodiles with long, thin snouts that are good for catching fish.

The Great Sphinx of Giza, a giant statue with a lion's body and a human head, is one of ancient Egypt's most famous monuments and is known for its missing nose.

Break it down

LEAD: A new extinct crocodile shares the Great Sphinx's famous missing nose

KEY EVENT: *Herugavialis cairensis* described in Royal Society Open Science

+ WHO: Researchers including Philip Mannion and Paul Burke

+ WHAT: A gavial, a long-snouted crocodile

+ WHERE: Skull from Egypt's 45-million-year-old Mokattam Formation, found in the 1920s

EVIDENCE: Re-study with new tools showed it was not the living false gharial

CONTEXT: Gavials once lived worldwide; crocodile diversity rose and fell with temperature and sea level

OUTCOME: Crocodiles vanished from the region when the Mediterranean dried up about 6 million years ago

Why it matters

Re-examining old museum fossils with new tools can reveal species no one knew about. It also shows how changes in temperature and sea level shaped which animals could survive.

Test what you remember

1. What is the name of the new crocodile species?
 - (A) Tomistoma schlegelii
 - (B) Gavialis gangeticus
 - (C) Herugavialis cairensis
 - (D) Crocodylus niloticus
2. What feature does the fossil share with the Great Sphinx?
 - (A) A missing tip of the snout or nose
 - (B) A lion's body
 - (C) A human head
 - (D) Gold decorations
3. What is a gavial?
 - (A) An Egyptian statue
 - (B) A crocodile with a long, thin snout
 - (C) A kind of ancient fish
 - (D) A type of rock layer
4. When were the crocodile fossils first dug up?
 - (A) Last year
 - (B) In the 1920s
 - (C) 4,500 years ago
 - (D) In the 1800s
5. Why were scientists able to tell it was a new species?
 - (A) They found a living one
 - (B) New tools made it easier to look inside fossil skulls
 - (C) They found its eggs
 - (D) They read ancient Egyptian writing
6. What caused all crocodiles to disappear from the Mediterranean region?
 - (A) The Mediterranean drying up about 6 million years ago
 - (B) Hunting by people
 - (C) Building the Sphinx
 - (D) A volcano

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: A 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Philip Mannion, University College London: Explains the team named the crocodile after the Egyptian god Heru because of the missing-nose coincidence.
2. Paul Burke, Swedish Museum of Natural History: Says crocodile variety in the Mediterranean rose and fell with temperature and sea level changes.

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MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):